WHO TAUGHT THE ROBOT?

Companion document · Make 10: AI & Labor · Adeline Bohi · Topic: Data labeling

RESEARCH NOTES (295 WORDS)

I relied on three kinds of sources. Investigative journalism gave the strongest evidence: Billy Perrigo's TIME investigation of OpenAI's Sama contracts in Kenya, and Rebecca Tan and Regine Cabato's Washington Post reporting on Scale AI's Remotasks platform in the Philippines. For numbers, I used Hara et al.'s peer-reviewed study of 3.8 million Mechanical Turk tasks, which found a median wage of about $2 an hour. For framing, I used Gray and Suri's Ghost Work through reviews and summaries, plus the Hicks reading on systems with built-in assumptions. I also used reporting on the Data Labelers Association and the content moderators' alliance for the call to action.

The hardest part was finding the other side of the story. Companies rarely disclose vendors, wages or contract values, so most figures come from reviewed payslips, worker interviews and company rebuttals that disagree. Sama, for example, disputes TIME's numbers, so I included both. Reports also conflict on the amount Scale AI paid to settle its lawsuits, so I said only that the suits were settled. Fairwork's rating of Scale AI reached me through secondary coverage, and I have marked it "as reported." I did not read Ghost Work in full, only reviews and summaries, so I cite it for its framing rather than for new data.

What surprised me most was the scale of the gap in who benefits. The Kenyan filter contracts were worth about $200,000 while OpenAI was reportedly seeking a $29 billion valuation. I came to think a direct comparison would be misleading, because a contract price is not a wage and a valuation is not revenue, so the zine says that outright. I was also surprised that workers are organizing despite the risks, with many members of the Data Labelers Association keeping their membership secret.

DESIGN STATEMENT (243 WORDS)

I chose a digital zine because the format is built to be passed around. A PDF can be shared on a group chat or printed and folded, and the zine tradition of cheap, direct, political print suits a topic about people who are usually left out of the story. The eight-page sequence moves from the problem to the people, conditions, profits, analysis and a call to act, so readers get a clear path from "what is this?" to "what can I do?"

My audience is students and other everyday AI users, people who use chatbots without thinking about how they were built. I did not want to lecture them. The cover opens with a chat bubble they recognize and then shows who stands behind it. I want readers to feel a small jolt of recognition, then curiosity and some discomfort, and to leave with something concrete to do. Page 7 gives five actions, from sharing the zine to asking AI companies about their labeling vendors.

For accessibility, the body text is 11.5 to 12 point, contrast is high (black on cream or yellow), headings follow one consistent hierarchy, and each chart has a text alternative. For honesty, I put a content warning on the trauma section, included Sama's counter-claims, and warned readers not to read a valuation as a pay gap. The yellow, black and red palette and the thick outlines give it a xeroxed zine look while keeping it easy to read.

ATTRIBUTION

Images: All graphics are original vector art and CSS created for the zine; no photos or third-party images are used. No AI image generator was used.
Tools: Claude (Anthropic) for research assistance, drafting and layout code; HTML/CSS; Google Chrome (PDF export); DejaVu fonts.

- Perrigo, B. (2023, Jan. 18). Exclusive: OpenAI used Kenyan workers on less than $2 per hour to make ChatGPT less toxic. *TIME*. time.com/6247678/openai-chatgpt-kenya-workers/
- Tan, R., & Cabato, R. (2023, Aug. 28). Behind the AI boom, an army of overseas workers in “digital sweatshops.” *The Washington Post*. washingtonpost.com/world/2023/08/28/scale-ai-remotasks-philippines-artificial-intelligence/
- Hara, K., Adams, A., Milland, K., Savage, S., Callison-Burch, C., & Bigham, J. (2018). A data-driven analysis of workers’ earnings on Amazon Mechanical Turk. *CHI 2018*. arxiv.org/abs/1712.05796
- Gray, M. L., & Suri, S. (2019). *Ghost work: How to stop Silicon Valley from building a new global underclass.* Houghton Mifflin Harcourt. (Read via Kirkus Reviews and MIT IDE summaries.)
- Kirkus Reviews. Review of *Ghost Work*. kirkusreviews.com/book-reviews/mary-l-gray/ghost-work
- Hicks, M. “Hacking the Cis-tem” (course reading, as framed in the assignment).
- King & Siegel LLP (2025). Scale AI misclassification settlement / class action. kingsiegel.com; Virginia Lawyers Weekly (2025, Jan. 28). AI company sued for wage theft, misclassification; TechCrunch (2025, Mar. 6). Scale AI is being investigated by the US Department of Labor; hyper.ai (2025). Scale AI to settle California worker lawsuits.
- Fairwork rating of Scale AI / Remotasks (2023), as reported in *Labor Exploitation at Scale* (gettingrealaboutai.substack.com) and tynanfiles.beehiiv.com.
- Computer Weekly (2025). Kenyan AI workers form Data Labelers Association; WageIndicator (2025). Data Labelers Association speaks up for invisible workers; The Gig Work Podcast S0/E17; UNI Global Union (2025, Apr. 30). Content moderators launch first-ever global alliance.
- Columbia Journalism Review, Tow Center. Q&A: Uncovering the labor exploitation that powers AI.